

You don't need CLI

Let the model drive the terminal. Let an Orb host it.



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The terminal used to be a rite of passage

We learned `git`, `ssh`, `grep`, `docker`, and a hundred flags we still Google.

Terminal fluency felt like **proof you were a real engineer.**

```
$ git rebase -i HEAD~3  
$ docker compose up -d  
$ gh pr create --fill  
$ pnpm run typecheck  
$ man tar # again
```

Everyone in this room has typed these. Most of us still look up the flags.

Your laptop became the bottleneck

Every tool ships a CLI. Every agent wants a checkout, a port, a browser.

Run three agents locally and you're babysitting **worktrees, conflicting processes, and fans at full speed.**

Thorsten Ball · 4 August 2026

Now that I don't have to worry about any of this — not how many checkouts I have ... or whether there's processes conflicting or ports being already open — I spawn so many more agents.

"What I Want to Tell You About Orbs"
amrcode.com/notes/what-i-want-to-tell-you-about-orbs

Imagine closing your laptop early

You describe the outcome. The agent does the work somewhere else.

You come back to **proof**, not a pile of terminal output.

It didn't take up anything! No checkout, no ports, no browser, nothing!

Thorsten Ball, after an agent ran 8–30 minutes testing its own work — while his phone was back in his pocket.

“I just need a better terminal setup”

More tmux panes. More worktrees. Sharper dotfiles.
A faster laptop.

It helps — until **one machine** is running every agent, every server, and you.

More panes

More agents to watch, not fewer things to do.

More worktrees

More checkouts to create, sync, and clean up.

Bigger laptop

Same ceiling, just higher. Still one machine.

You don't need CLI

Models already read `--help`, run the commands, and parse the output better than we do.

Amp is the vessel. **Orbs** are where it lives: parallel, isolated, ephemeral cloud sandboxes.

Amp team · Alex Kemper · 10 August 2026

85%

of Amp's own commits now come from Orbs — and their commit velocity rose 65% in the month since Orbs shipped.

— [Pave the Road](#)

Three shifts, no new commands

You already have every skill this needs.

You're trading **typing commands** for **stating intent** and **judging proof**.

State the outcome

"Open a PR that fixes the broken footer link" — not the `git` incantation.

Move off your laptop

Spawn it in an Orb. No checkout, no ports, no fans.



Demand proof

Tests, screenshots, a video. Review evidence, not transcripts.

Tonight: spawn one Orb

1. Sign in at **ampcode.com**
2. Start an agent in an Orb on a repo you own
3. Give it one real papercut, in plain language
4. Ask for proof it works, then close the tab
5. While it runs, spawn a second one

Every time I see a papercut I take a screenshot, start an agent in an orb and let it rip.

Thorsten Ball — the habit to steal.

What you get back this week

- no local setup, no port clashes
- more agents running in parallel
- steering from web, phone, or desktop
- a lighter review load, because agents bring proof

Instead of:

one agent, one terminal, you watching every line scroll by.

You get:

several agents in several Orbs, each returning with screenshots, test runs, or a demo video.

The terminal becomes plumbing

Like assembly: still there, still essential, rarely typed by hand.

Engineers spend their time on **what to build and whether it works** — not on how to invoke it.

Thorsten Ball · 4 August 2026

There's basically very very few things left that require a **local dev environment**.

"... the next big change, a bigger change possibly than coding agents themselves."

Live Demo

Zero commands typed by me. For as long as the room wants.

 You pick the tasks. The agents run the CLI. We judge the proof.

How the demo works

1. **Spawn** (15 min) — first Orb on this very website's repo
2. **Pick** (15 min) — you shout papercuts, we vote on three
3. **Fan out** (30 min) — one Orb per task, running in parallel
4. **Proof** (30 min) — review screenshots, tests, videos together
5. **Ship** (30 min) — the agent opens the PR; we decide to merge

Each round stands alone. We can stop after any of them.

Ground rule:

I won't type a single shell command. If something needs a CLI, the agent runs it.

Backup plan, if the room is shy:

Build this deck's PDF and og-image in an Orb, then list the talk on zainfathoni.com/talks.

CLIs we'll watch the agent run

The commands don't disappear. They just stop being my job:

- `git` / `gh` — branches, commits, pull requests
- `pnpm` — install, typecheck, build
- `playwright` — browser proof
- `marp` — slides, like these ones

```
# typed by the agent, not me
$ pnpm install
$ pnpm run typecheck ✓
$ gh pr create --fill ✓
```

Watch the transcript, not the keyboard.

References

- Thorsten Ball — [What I Want to Tell You About Orbs](#) (4 August 2026)
- Alex Kemper — [Pave the Road](#) (10 August 2026)
- [Amp](#) — the coding agent used in the demo
- Dan Roam — [The Pop-Up Pitch](#) (this talk's storyline)
- Zain Fathoni — [Fundamental CS for AI Era](#)

**Stop operating the terminal.
Start judging the proof.**

Q & A

zainfathoni.com/you-dont-need-cli.html

ampcode.com

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